

Dear Jen,

I might have too much time on my hands: today I started reading the Manual for the Uniform Code of Military Justice. I plan to read it cover to cover. I figured, why not? If I want to be a lawyer some day, I might as well get comfortable with these types of manuals. I already read about the different punitive articles and tomorrow I will read about all the procedures. Unfortunately the book must be around 1000 pages long so it may take some time to understand all of the different concepts.

Not much happened today, but there was a lot going on. The Colonel and the XO spent a good portion of the day lingering around the TOC—always a pleasure. At one point, Colonel Ingram received a radio call from the Brigade XO changing the concept of tomorrow's mission, a raid in Abu Ghurayb. When their conversation was over, Colonel Ingram threw the radio hand mike against the wall and stormed off. It's the little things like this that make for a stressful day.

In addition, most of the battalion will wake up early tomorrow morning in preparation for a "snatch and grab" mission with the Special Forces Task Force. The commander, the XO, and the S-3 all requested wake up times around 2 a.m. The start time for the mission is 0500. Thank God that I don't come on duty until tomorrow afternoon. Most of the hubbub should be long over. Lt. Simonson, on the other hand, will have his work cut out for him. I'm sure that he will get a little taste of what Sproesser and I went through back in Al Hillah. Nothing is more tedious than the TOC during a battle. Major Wick will pace around the TOC, barking out commands, as the Colonel monitors every transmission on the radio. Time moves slowly, and there is so much going on. The Battle Captains are very busy and no matter what you do, you will always be in the way. Yes, I am glad that I will not be on duty during this raid.

On a more solemn note, I wrote a counseling statement for Specialist Gonzalez yesterday evening. I was not excited about the fact that I was damaging his career, and possibly his future in the Army, but it had to be done. Specialist Gonzalez has been in the Army for several years and was, at one time, a Sergeant. Unfortunately for him, he has a big mouth that always gets him in trouble. This was one of the first things I noticed about him when I met him some time ago.

He is a little guy in his early twenties, and of prominent Spanish decent. He likes to play the big shot, always on a crusade against the evil command structure that, in his eyes, is only designed to keep him down. He is difficult to work with, and his apprehension of people in supervisory roles, makes it difficult for him to garner support when he gets himself in trouble—which he most certainly does. Two examples of this occurred during my first two encounters with him. Without every having met me, Specialist Gonzalez felt it was necessary to tell me that he had "taken more shits in the field than I have spent time in the Army." At the time, the comment seemed out of place and rude, but I did not know him so I let it slide. I simply blew him off telling him that "I could not help it if I

chose a different route than he did." On my second encounter with Gonzalez, I had asked him to do something—even though I don't remember what it was, I know that it was something small and fairly mundane. He responded by stating that he did not join to Army to "sit on his ass," and he "preferred adventure and working with his hands." At this point, Captain Nutt took offense to his insinuation about our job in the TOC, and proceeded to lock him up. Captain Nutt expressed a valid, yet humorous observation, asking him if being a HMMWV driver was any different than just "sitting on his ass."

Anyhow, it has been a long time since all this occurred and I didn't really think about it much until more recently. In the past few days, Specialist Gonzalez has dug a new, and much deeper, hole for himself. He was on a detail with SSG Ashbaugh, one of the NCOs in our S-4 shop, when he decided he didn't like the detail he was assigned. Rather than sucking it up, he decided to be mouthy with SSG Ashbaugh resulting in an Article 15 (non-judicial punishment).

This, in itself, is not too bad. It sucks because an Article 15 usually costs the soldier some money, \$256, and they have to do extra duty for 14 days. As if this were not enough, Gonzalez decided he didn't like the duties he had during extra duty either. He then protested each and every task SSG Franklin gave him until he finally went overboard. He got into with SSG Franklin saying fuck this and fuck that. He even threatened to kill himself and make it look like an accident. As a result, he got another Article 15, was demoted from Specialist to Private, E-1, and sent to the Psychiatric Unit for further evaluation.

Now, this is a guy with two kids and a wife. He just lost several hundred dollars a month in pay and is in serious danger of being discharged from the Army under other-than honorable conditions. What is he thinking? All I could think when I was writing up the paperwork was "Why?" Why would he do this to himself? I wish there would have been a way to find out the cause of his anger and resentment, and I wish that he was willing to work out his problems.

Love

Christie

Dear Jen,

I guess I never finished that other letter. Oops. One thing that I don't like about being over here is the mood swings. Everyone has them now, and I have had them for some time. One day I am alright with being here and with my job, the next day it feels like the walls of the TOC are collapsing in on me. Today is one of those days. I am fed up with being in Iraq, and in the TOC more specifically. I want to get out and do something. Two days ago I asked Major Cribb if he could switch me out of the TOC, for part-time at least. He told me that he would ask the Colonel but he has not gotten back to me yet. This reminds me of the tank-recovery mission that never happened and the 55-Gallon Drum of possible chemical weapons that I never got to go check out. It is so frustrating to have a job that doesn't matter, and one that no one cares about. The worst part is that, not only do I not get to do what I am trained for, but I get stuck with this bitch-job and can't get away from it—ever! Today, Captain Nutt and Captain Hamilton were joking that the only reason the Battalion needs a chemical officer is for the USR each month. Unfortunately, they are right.

Captain Hamilton is leaving the TOC at the end of the month to take command of Alpha company, and we are getting a new battle captain. His name is Captain Querreria, or some shit like that. He is from "Los Angeles," but not really. He is actually from some suburb, and he was a staff captain at Brigade before coming to us. He is a spanish guy and I don't know if I like him. I can't help but associate all spanish guys with Juan from the Red Cross, and I automatically have a bad impression of them. I will have to get over that since I am now forced to work with him everyday. He seems very business-like, and has not taken too much time to talk to anyone other than the battle captains since first showing up here two days ago. I'm not looking forward to the transition, which will surely come with changes of its own.

I'm sure Captain Nutt will be the next in line for a new position, and then, he too will escape this hellhole. Our commander does a good job of making sure that no one person gets stuck working in the TOC, except for the chemical officer. AAAAAH, FUCK. I need to just accept the fact that there is nothing I can do about it, and that I will never do anything that relates to my training. I can't believe that I volunteered to work in this bullshit branch.

To add to my frustration today—besides the claustrophobia that is setting in from being trapped in this same room day after day—I received a letter from a company in Manhattan. They are having a seminar for officers looking to transfer to the corporate world. The company is called PCS, and specializes in helping officers with less than twelve years experience in the military find jobs in corporate America. I read the letter with jealous envy. I want to go to the meeting so badly. They say that they can help you determine what jobs to look for and help you figure out how much you can expect to make on the outside. Sounds like the perfect seminar—and it's free. Right now, sitting

here in Iraq, I can't wait for my chance to attend one of these conferences. I can't wait to be free of this manacle of a chemical corps patch on my collar.

Otherwise, it is still hot and hazy here in the city, and I am having a difficult time staying awake today—not to mention paying attention to the radio. As for actual work, I have given that up for some time. I don't try to be too proactive anymore, and just muddle through the day. It's more like passing the time than it is actually working. I try to ignore everything that is going on to such an extent that I know just enough to answer a general question, but not acquire enough information to clutter my brain with this incessant chatter. If I can't answer the question, I just call that unit back and make them give it to me again. It works. I am just too burnt out right now. No surprise really, when you consider that I have worked twelve hours per day, every day, for the last three months—without ever getting away from one square little table.

Now I have gotten it off my chest. I dream of going back to graduate school and getting out of this type of job. This is exactly the type of job that I was trying to avoid by joining the Army. Oh well, at least we have some cash and a place to live. We can always make modifications to our careers later.

Love,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Christian', with a long, sweeping horizontal line extending to the right.

Christian